Life of the Mediocre Mathematician

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Mathematics often seems as though it is the gold standard of rigor, the pinnacle of excellence at least within circles of academia. I don't want to proclaim that I chose to study mathematics because of this connotation, but I'll say that its prowess wasn't anything that dissuaded me from the field of study.

While my initial motivation may have been extremely egotistical, I came to find an intrinsic beauty within mathematics. The telos of axiomatized mathematics was something that I found innately different from any other field I had previously attempted to fall for. I felt I had to force myself to become enamored with philosophy or physics, but there was something about the "definition, lemma, theorem" way of presenting a body of work that just spoke to me.

It was the first time I really found beauty within something so analytical. I spoke about the motivation and results of complex analysis as if they were the multicolored brushstrokes on a Hiroshige piece. The pink that vibrated seemingly off the page that made all my friends who loved art vibrate with emotion, I felt that same way with Louisville's theorem.

Honestly I don't really know what it is, and I don't know if I can attempt to describe it without seeming overly pretentious about my love for it. But mathematics has this quality about it, this flow, the way of putting together truth within itself that is unlike anything I have ever studied or attempted to understand.

For something that speaks about limits as much as it does, the possibilities of mathematics often feels unbounded, almost freeing. I had a friend ask me if studying the abstraction of thought felt freeing. And that was really the first time I was able to put words to it. Mathematics to me feels otherworldly. As though I'm floating above all the worries I have within the tangible realm, and am able to escape to a momentary paradise where everything is self-sustaining and formally enduring.

You may not believe it from the raving I have about mathematics, but for a long portion of my life I was what you would call a humanities kid. I wanted to study history, the "why's?" of the world, the philosophical underpinnings of how humans came to perceive the world around them. Likely a very vain choice on my end (growing up in Taiwan a community that put so much emphasis on STEM education and a learnedness of the "hard" sciences) but I fell in love with mathematics first as a form of truth.

I wrote in many of my essays for university that I enjoyed mathematics because it was the only thing we knew was unambiguous. It was the color that artists painted with, no matter what form they decided to depict, the blue of a midnight sky was always going to be just that, the same Hex code that depicted that empty blanket of a canvas, waiting to be portrayed by the stars above.

But a year and some change into my life studying mathematics not for the analysis of it, but rather for the purity, I've come to change how I feel. I never knew how to write a proof, I look back at my first class studying linear algebra and some of the page long proofs I wrote about why a subset contained every element of the parent set and I cringe at the attempted rigor when in reality, I was going in circles around the real crux of the problem.

Mathematics to me has become an art more than anything. I'm going to get a little jargon heavy so bear with me everyone that is a nonmathematician for a while. But if you consider the range of humanities to STEM as R/Z, you'll realize that it's isomorphic to S1. What does that mean? The love that I had of mathematics was really the initial motivation for why I enjoyed more of the "humanities".

Really what I'm trying to say with those who were lost in the math jargon is that the scale of humanities to STEM is nothing more than circular, one that begins exactly where it started. The vector space of knowledge is one that is often characterized and judged based on its norm (or the magnitude of output or difficulty that it takes to understand), but understanding is nothing more than the friction it takes us to internalize a concept. That's why I think I love mathematics so much, it's a surface that has a friction coefficient so high, it's never been easy for me to move forward.

Maybe that's why there's no room for someone like me. Someone who loves math because it challenges them.

A lot of my colleagues and friends who end up in mathematics feel as though there was a divine prophecy bestowed upon them, one that said they were made to study the language of the heavenly.

That's not me.

And it's not me being humble. I know deep down in my own heart that it's simply not who I was born to be.

And so I'm unsure, in the age where knowledge is so readily available to obtain, in the age where excellence nothing short of perfection is expected. Is there space for someone like me?

The mediocre mathematician?

Who just loves its beauty.

But is unable to prove it?